

Sifaat — Letter Characteristics

■ This is a study companion for your Tajweed course. Each bullet point is a key concept from the video lecture. Review these pointers before or after each lesson.

What Are Sifaat?

- Sifaat = characteristics that distinguish letters sharing the same makhraj
- Example: Taa (■) and Taa (■) have similar makhraj but very different sifaat
- Without sifaat, Arabic would only need 17 letters (one per makhraj)
- Sifaat explain why we have 28 distinct letters from 17 articulation points

Heavy vs Light — The Most Important Distinction

- HEAVY (■■■■■■■■■ / Tafkheem): tongue raised, throat opens, vowels sound deep ('o' like)
- LIGHT (■■■■■■■■■ / Tarqeeq): tongue relaxed, vowels sound clear and thin
- The 7 ALWAYS HEAVY letters: Saad (■) Daad (■) Taa (■) Dhaa (■) Qaaf (■) Ghayn (■) Kha (■)
- Mnemonic for heavy letters: ■■■■■■ ■■■■■■ ■■■■■■
- ALL other letters are ALWAYS LIGHT
- Raa (■) and Laam (■) can be heavy OR light depending on surrounding vowels

The Special Rule for Laam in 'Allah'

- HEAVY when preceded by Fatha or Damma:
 - qaala-LLAAHU (■■■■■■ ■■■■■■) — heavy laam
 - rasoolul-LLAAHI (■■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■) — heavy laam
- LIGHT when preceded by Kasra:
 - bismil-laahi (■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■) — light laam
 - alhamdu lil-laahi (■■■■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■■) — light laam
- This is one of the most beautiful rules in Tajweed — natural sound flow

Whispered (Hams) vs Voiced (Jahr)

- WHISPERED (■■■■■■■■■) — 10 letters: air escapes freely when pronounced
 - Letters: ■■■■■■■■■■
 - Mnemonic: ■■■■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■ ■■■■■■
- VOICED (■■■■■■■■■) — remaining 19 letters: vocal cords vibrate, no air escape
- Test: hold a tissue near your mouth — whispered letters move it, voiced don't

Strong (Shidda) vs Soft (Rakhawa)

- STRONG (■■■■■ ■■■■) — 8 letters: sound stops completely at articulation point
Letters: ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ — Mnemonic: ■■■■■■ ■■■■■■ ■■■■■■
- SOFT (■■■■■ ■■■■■ ■■■■■): sound flows continuously
Example: Seen (■) — air flows. Ba (■) — sound stops.
- MEDIUM (■■■■■ ■■■■■ ■■■■■): partial stop — 5 letters: ■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Practical Application

- When reciting Quran, ALWAYS check: is this letter heavy or light?
- Heavy letters affect ALL surrounding vowels — the whole word sounds deeper
- Example: ██████████ — the Saad makes the whole word heavy
- vs ██████████ (if incorrectly used) — the Seen keeps it light
- Recite Al-Fatiha slowly, identifying heavy and light letters in each word